

01 · THE SERIES

SAFETY, SPACE, AND REPETITION

WHEN SHUTDOWN ISN'T ATTITUDE



WHAT LOOKS LIKE ATTITUDE MIGHT BE A NERVOUS SYSTEM PROTECTING ITSELF.



THE SERIES

FIVE LESSONS. ONE PLAYER.

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When Shutdown Isn't Attitude

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Why 'Just Get Over It' Doesn't Work

Coming up.

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The Pause Instead of the Spiral

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Separating Then From Now

Coming up.

HEAR THIS ONCE

THE ATHLETE WHO SHUTS DOWN
AFTER FEEDBACK IS NOT BEING
DRAMATIC OR DISRESPECTFUL, SHE
MAY BE RESPONDING TO A THREAT
THAT NO LONGER EXISTS.

When a child has had a negative experience with coaching, her brain links feedback to danger. Every piece of feedback from a new coach is a flashback, and the body responds accordingly. This is not attitude. It's protection.

— THE BODY DOES NOT FORGET · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE SHUTDOWN PATTERN

BEFORE LABELING IT AS
ATTITUDE, ASK: WHAT DID HER
NERVOUS SYSTEM LEARN, AND
FROM WHOM?

- Shutdown behaviors: going quiet, getting defensive, eye rolling, withdrawing, saying she wants to quit
- These behaviors also appear on lists of 'uncoachable' or 'attitude problem', they are often neither
- The nervous system is not responding to this coach. It is responding to a past one.

— THE NERVOUS SYSTEM RESPONDS TO MEMORY. HELP HER BUILD NEW ONES.

WHAT SHUTDOWN LOOKS LIKE

OBVIOUS SIGNS

Crying, emotional breakdown, refusing to participate: these get noticed and addressed.

QUIET SIGNS

Going silent, subtle withdrawal, eye rolling, shortened responses: these get mislabeled.

THE COMMON THREAD

Both are protection patterns: not personality defects. The treatment is safety, not discipline.



READING THE SIGNAL

IN PRACTICE

After a shutdown moment: don't push for conversation. Offer presence. 'I'm here. You don't have to talk.'

WATCH FOR

Whether the shutdown follows any feedback, even neutral, or specifically harsh delivery.

THE SHIFT

From reacting to the behavior to investigating the pattern beneath it.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

SHE IS NOT BEING DRAMATIC. HER
NERVOUS SYSTEM IS BEING HONEST.
THAT HONESTY DESERVES A REAL
RESPONSE.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, OBSERVE THE SHUTDOWN PATTERN.

✓ Watch for one shutdown moment: in practice, at home, or in any feedback context

✓ Note the trigger: what specifically preceded the shutdown?

✓ Respond with presence, not pressure: 'I see you. Take your time.'

✓ Begin a log: what triggers the shutdown, and what helps it pass?



SAFETY, SPACE, AND REPETITION

WHY 'JUST GET
OVER IT' DOESN'T WORK

02

LOGIC DOESN'T WORK WHEN THE NERVOUS SYSTEM IS IN PROTECTION MODE.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

TELLING AN ATHLETE TO 'JUST GET OVER IT' OR 'THIS COACH ISN'T LIKE THAT COACH' IS LOGICALLY CORRECT AND EMOTIONALLY USELESS.

Her nervous system is not making a cognitive error. It is making an emotional one. And emotional responses do not respond to logical instructions. They respond to safety, repetition, and new experience.

— LOGIC DOESN'T REACH THE NERVOUS SYSTEM · MAZEPERFORMANCE

WHAT WORKS INSTEAD

INSTEAD OF CONVINCING HER,
BUILD NEW EXPERIENCES THAT
TEACH HER NERVOUS SYSTEM
SOMETHING DIFFERENT.

- Safety: create environments where feedback is consistently warm, calm, and growth-focused
- Space: allow processing time without forcing conversation, pressure during shutdown compounds it
- Repetition: new positive feedback experiences, built up over time, rewire the association

— THE NERVOUS SYSTEM LEARNS THROUGH EXPERIENCE. BUILD THE EXPERIENCES.

05 · THE BREAKDOWN

WHAT DOESN'T WORK

'JUST MOVE ON'

Dismisses the nervous system response without addressing its source.

'THIS COACH IS DIFFERENT'

True, but the nervous system doesn't process verbal reassurance as proof.

PUSHING FOR CONVERSATION

Forcing processing before the window opens can compound the shutdown.



WHAT DOES WORK

IN PRACTICE

Give feedback in small doses in low-stakes, warm environments: build the new memory.

WATCH FOR

The window: there is always a moment, usually 30-60 minutes later, when she's ready to talk. Wait for it.

THE SHIFT

From trying to override the shutdown to building the conditions where it naturally shrinks.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

YOU CANNOT TALK HER OUT OF A
NERVOUS SYSTEM RESPONSE. BUILD
NEW EXPERIENCES THAT TEACH HER
DIFFERENTLY.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, CREATE ONE NEW POSITIVE FEEDBACK EXPERIENCE.

✓ Choose a low-stakes moment, not practice, not post-match, to give one warm, specific piece of feedback

✓ Watch her response: does she receive it differently in a different context?

✓ Repeat once more this week, different setting, same warm delivery

✓ Track over four weeks: is the window between feedback and reception getting shorter?



SAFETY, SPACE, AND REPETITION

BUILDING SAFETY
IN FEEDBACK
ENVIRONMENTS

03

SAFETY IS NOT SOFTNESS. IT IS THE PREREQUISITE FOR GROWTH.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

ATHLETES WHO DON'T FEEL
EMOTIONALLY SAFE IN THEIR FEEDBACK
ENVIRONMENT CANNOT RECEIVE
COACHING, NO MATTER HOW
TECHNICALLY SKILLED THE COACH IS.

Emotional safety is not about avoiding hard feedback. It is about creating the conditions where hard feedback can actually land. Without safety, coaching becomes noise at best and trauma at worst.

— SAFETY IS THE PREREQUISITE FOR GROWTH · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE SAFETY CONDITIONS

BEFORE YOUR ATHLETE CAN
GROW FROM COACHING, SHE
NEEDS TO FEEL SAFE ENOUGH TO
RECEIVE IT.

- Consistency: the feedback environment is predictable, not randomly harsh or suddenly warm
- Dignity: corrections happen in ways that protect her self-worth, not perform for others
- Recovery: when hard moments happen, there is a clear path back, not lingering punishment

— YOU CANNOT COACH SOMEONE OUT OF PROTECTION MODE. CREATE SAFETY FIRST.

THE SAFETY SIGNALS

PREDICTABILITY

The athlete knows what to expect. No surprises in tone or severity. The environment is stable.

PRIVACY

Corrections happen in ways that don't expose the athlete's vulnerabilities to the group.

REPAIR

When things get hard, there is a clear, warm path back, not unresolved tension or cold withdrawal.



BUILDING SAFETY

IN PRACTICE

After a hard practice moment, find a quiet moment to reconnect: this closes the loop and rebuilds safety.

WATCH FOR

Whether the athlete approaches the coach after hard moments or consistently avoids her.

THE SHIFT

From hoping she toughens up to building the safety conditions that make growth possible.



SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

SAFETY IS NOT ABOUT AVOIDING
DIFFICULTY. IT'S ABOUT BUILDING
THE ENVIRONMENT WHERE DIFFICULTY
CAN BE LEARNED FROM.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, AUDIT THE FEEDBACK ENVIRONMENT FOR SAFETY.

- ✓ Ask: is the feedback environment predictable, dignified, and repairable?
- ✓ Identify one place where safety is inconsistent and name it
- ✓ Make one change this week that increases predictability in how feedback is delivered
- ✓ After a hard coaching moment, check in with your athlete in a warm, private way

SAFETY, SPACE, AND REPETITION

THE PAUSE
INSTEAD OF THE SPIRAL



TEACH HER TO PAUSE INSTEAD OF SPIRAL. THAT SINGLE SKILL CHANGES EVERYTHING.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

ATHLETES WHO SPIRAL AFTER COACHING DON'T LACK MENTAL TOUGHNESS, THEY LACK A SPECIFIC SKILL: THE ABILITY TO INTERRUPT THE SPIRAL WITH A DELIBERATE PAUSE.

The spiral is automatic. The pause is trained. Every athlete can learn to interrupt a spiral — but only if she has been given a specific, practiced tool to do it with.

— THE PAUSE IS A SKILL, NOT A PERSONALITY TRAIT · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE PAUSE TOOL

BETWEEN THE TRIGGER AND THE
SPIRAL, THERE IS A MOMENT.
TRAIN HER TO FIND IT.

- The trigger: feedback lands and the nervous system starts to respond
- The gap: between receiving the feedback and the first spiral thought, this is where the pause lives
- The tool: a physical action that occupies the gap, breath, cue word, movement

— THE PAUSE IS NOT PASSIVITY. IT IS THE MOST ACTIVE THING SHE WILL DO IN THAT MOMENT.

THE GAP

THE AUTOMATIC

Without training, the gap closes instantly and the spiral begins.



THE TRAINED

With a practiced tool, the gap is held open long enough to choose the next thought.

THE TOOL

One breath, one word, one movement: the exact tool matters less than the practice of using it.

06 · THE APPLICATION

INSTALLING THE PAUSE

IN PRACTICE

Choose one pause tool together: deep breath, the word 'next,' touching the court.

WATCH FOR

Whether she uses the tool in low-stakes moments: that's the training that matters.

THE SHIFT

From trying to avoid the spiral to having a deliberate interruption ready before it starts.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

THE SPIRAL DOESN'T HAVE TO WIN
EVERY TIME. GIVE HER A TOOL FOR
THE GAP, AND TRAIN IT BEFORE SHE
NEEDS IT.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, INSTALL ONE PAUSE TOOL.

✓ Choose the pause tool together: breath, word, or physical action

✓ Practice it in a zero-stakes setting five times before practice

✓ Use it in practice: after a mistake, before the next play

✓ Debrief once this week: 'Did you use the pause? What happened?'



SAFETY, SPACE, AND REPETITION

SEPARATING
THEN FROM NOW

OS

THE OLD COACH IS NOT HERE. TEACH HER NERVOUS SYSTEM TO KNOW THE DIFFERENCE.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

THE MOST IMPORTANT LONG-TERM SKILL IN THIS WORK IS HELPING ATHLETES DISTINGUISH BETWEEN WHAT HAPPENED THEN AND WHAT IS HAPPENING NOW.

This is the core of the rewire: the athlete needs to develop the ability, over time and with support, to see each feedback environment as its own, separate from the past. This is a long game. And it is worth playing.

— TEACH HER TO LIVE IN THE PRESENT MOMENT · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE SEPARATION

THE NERVOUS SYSTEM RESPONDS
TO MEMORY. YOUR JOB IS TO
HELP HER BUILD ENOUGH NEW
MEMORIES THAT THE OLD ONES
STOP RUNNING THE SHOW.

- Past response: automatic, fast, based on old data, the body protecting from something that no longer exists
- Present reality: this coach, this environment, this moment, often very different from the past
- The practice: name the difference, consistently, until the nervous system learns it

— THE OLD COACH IS NOT HERE. THE PAST IS NOT THE PRESENT. TEACH HER TO KNOW THE DIFFERENCE.

THE LONG GAME

TIMELINE

This is not a one-conversation fix. The nervous system rewires through new experiences, not new information.

MARKERS

Progress looks like: shorter shutdown windows, more questions asked, less body-based response to feedback.

CELEBRATION

Every small opening is worth naming. The moment she asks a question after feedback is a win.



THE LONG GAME STRATEGY

IN PRACTICE

Name the separation when you see it: 'That was a really different response from last month. Did you notice that?'

WATCH FOR

Small openings: a question asked, a nod given, a quicker return to play, these are the data points.

THE SHIFT

From measuring the size of the shutdown to measuring the speed of the recovery. Progress is in the recovery.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

THE OLD COACH WAS THEN. THIS IS
NOW. GIVE HER THE TOOLS TO TELL
THE DIFFERENCE, AND THE TIME TO
LEARN IT.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, NAME ONE MARKER OF PROGRESS.

✓ Look back at the last four weeks: is there one moment where the shutdown was shorter or less intense?

✓ Name it explicitly: 'Do you remember when you would have shut down for an hour? Today it was ten minutes.'

✓ Celebrate the recovery speed, not just the absence of the shutdown

✓ Commit to tracking this over the full season, not just a few weeks

